Peasant & Working-Class Movements

How the village and the mill joined — and pulled against — the national movement

0 own Mains but 3 linked 15-markers

Feeds **2020** social base · **2019** many voices · **2017** new objectives · **~16 Prelims** incl. **2026** Eka vs Bardoli

THE ANSWER SPINE 1 Local enemy, legal method → 2 Gandhi links grievance to nation → 3 Unions and the left → 4 Class adjustment → 5 1940s revolt → Qualify: autonomy vs integration

① EARLY PEASANT REVOLTS, 1857–1917

Prelims 1999 chronology · 1997 match

Revolt	Against · outcome
Indigo 1859–60	Planters, Bengal; Biswas brothers; *Nil Darpan* → Indigo Commission 1860
Pabna 1873–76	Zamindars' rents; legal leagues → Bengal Tenancy Act 1885
Deccan 1875	Moneylenders, Poona; bonds burnt → DAR Act 1879
Punjab 1907	Colonisation Bill; Ajit Singh, Lajpat Rai → Bill vetoed

Features: enemy local, not the Raj · legal, trusting British courts · no all-India body.

② GANDHIAN PHASE & KISAN SABHAS

2026 Eka vs Bardoli · 2019 AIKS · 2005 UP KS · 2003 Bardoli

- **Champaran 1917** — tinkathia 3/20; Rajkumar Shukla, Rajendra Prasad, Kripalani · **Kheda 1918** — revenue not suspended; Patel
- **UP Kisan Sabha Feb 1918** — Gauri Shankar Mishra, Indra Narain Dwivedi, Malaviya (**not** Nehru)
- **Awadh KS Oct 1920** — Baba Ramchandra, Nehru; nazrana, begar, eviction
- **Eka 1921–22** — Hardoi, Bahraich, Sitapur; **Madari Pasi**; rents; autonomous
- **Mappila 1921** — Malabar tenants vs jenmis; Khilafat; communal turn
- **Bardoli 1928** — revenue ~22% → ~6% (Maxwell–Broomfield); "Sardar" Patel
- **AIKS, Lucknow 1936** — **Sahajanand** (pres.), **Ranga** (sec.); Kisan Manifesto: zamindari abolition, rent cuts, debt relief
- **Faizpur 1936** agrarian programme · ministries' tenancy Acts 1937–39 · Bakasht (Bihar)

2026 contrast: Bardoli fought the **state** (revenue); Eka fought the **landlord** (rent).

The programme it won (2017 link): Karachi 1931 — fundamental rights and economic programme · Faizpur 1936 — agrarian programme · AIKS Kisan Manifesto 1936 → zamindari abolition on the agenda.

Peasants and Workers — the Four Axes

Your tracker's completion test, with achievements and limits

	PEASANTS	WORKERS
Grievance	Rent, revenue, eviction, cesses, planters, debt	Hours, wages, jobbers, no right to organise, war prices
Organisation	Local leagues → Kisan Sabhas 1918–20 → AIKS 1936	Clubs 1870s → unions 1918 → AITUC 1920 → splits 1929/31 → reunion
Ideology	Moral economy → Gandhian → socialist, communist	Philanthropy → nationalist → communist vs trusteeship
Linkage	Strong 1917–22, 1930–32, 1937, 1942	1908, 1919–22, 1945–46; weak 1930–32, split 1942
Gains	Tenancy and debt laws; zamindari abolition on agenda	TU Act 1926; factory laws; political class
Limits	Rich-peasant led; sharecroppers late; communal splits	Small, rural-rooted, divided; Congress tied to capitalists

THE RELATIONSHIP: they gave the movement a mass base and a social programme; it gave them a national voice — and restrained their class demands

COUNTER-CASES & HISTORIANS — WRITE ONE

AUTONOMY	INTEGRATION	READING GANDHI	LABOUR	BOMBAY
Ranajit Guha 1983: insurgency had its **own consciousness**	Bipan Chandra: **class adjustment** in a multi-class front	Shahid Amin 1984: peasants made their **own Mahatma**	Chakrabarty 1989: **community and hierarchy** over class	Chandavarkar 1994: **jobbers and neighbourhood** shaped the mills

③ WORKERS, 1870–1929

2017 Lokhande · 2009 ATLA · 2003 Whitley

- **Sasipada Banerjee** — Working Men's Club 1870 · **Lokhande** — Bombay Mill Hands' Association 1890
- Moderates opposed Factory Acts 1881/1891 (Lancashire motive) but backed **Assam tea labour**
- **1908** — Tuticorin (V. O. Chidambaram Pillai); **Bombay 6-day strike for Tilak** (Lenin)
- **Ahmedabad 1918** — Gandhi's fast, 35% · **ATLA 1920** (Anasuya Sarabhai) · **Madras LU 1918** (B. P. Wadia)
- **AITUC 31 Oct 1920** — Lajpat Rai, Chaman Lal, N. M. Joshi
- **TU Act 1926** · Trade Disputes Act 1929 · **Girni Kamgar** 1928 strike · **Meerut Case 1929** (Dange, Muzaffar Ahmed, Spratt) · Whitley 1929–31

④ SPLITS, WAR & WHY LABOUR WAS WEAK

2002 Prelims: weak in 1930s · 2018 HMS founders

Splits: 1929 Joshi's federation · 1931 Red TUC · reunited by 1940. **1930–32:** communists' "class against class" → labour weak in CDM. **1938** Bombay Trade Disputes Act angers unions. **1942:** CPI's "People's War" → out of Quit India, yet Tata Steel and Ahmedabad struck. **1945–46:** strike wave; Bombay strike for naval ratings.

Centres: INTUC 1947 (Congress) · **HMS 1948** (Ashok Mehta, T. S. Ramanujam, G. G. Mehta) · UTUC 1949.

Six reasons for weakness:

- Small workforce · rural roots, circular migration
- Jobbers controlled hiring
- Caste, region, language, religion
- Repression (Meerut, Public Safety)
- Ideological splits, Comintern swings
- Congress ties to Indian capital; trusteeship

Line: militant early, weak throughout — small, rural-rooted, divided, split.

10-mark frame: prove militancy first (1908, 1920, 1928) → six reasons → achievements (1926 Act, factory laws, political class) → "real but bounded".

⑤ THE 1940s — REVOLT IN THE FIELD

2013 Tebhaga · 1999/2000 Linlithgow on 1942

Quit India 1942: villages of Bihar, eastern UP, Midnapore, Satara; parallel governments (Ballia, Tamluk, Satara); Linlithgow: most serious since 1857.

Warli 1945 — Thane; Godavari Parulekar.

Punnapra-Vayalar 1946 — Travancore; coir workers vs C. P. Ramaswamy Iyer.

Tebhaga 1946–47 — Bengal *bargadars*; landlord's share ½ → ⅓; Floud Commission 1940; Bargadars Bill 1947.

Telangana 1946–51 — vs Nizam's deshmukhs and *vetti*; communist village soviets; ended 1951.

Line: in the 1940s class movements ran ahead of — and sometimes against — the Congress leadership.

15-mark frame — relationship with nationalism: distance (1857–1917) → integration (1917–22, 1930–32) → programme (Karachi, Faizpur, ministries) → tension (Eka, Mappila, Tebhaga, Telangana) → Guha vs Bipan Chandra → close on land reform after 1947.

THE VERDICT TO WRITE Peasants and workers fought local exploiters first; Gandhi drew them into the national movement, the left radicalised them, and the Congress gave them a programme — Karachi 1931, Faizpur 1936 — while holding back a war on landlords and mill-owners. *They gave nationalism its mass base and social conscience; nationalism gave them a voice and delayed their demands — the unfinished agenda became land reform and labour law after 1947.*